

Troubleshooting Common PPC Issues

A first-pass diagnosis table for the symptoms you'll see most often, and the order to check things in.

Quick diagnosis table

Symptom	Likely cause	First thing to check
ACOS spiked overnight	A high-spend, low-conversion search term slipped out of the	Review today's Search Term Report, sort by spend
Impressions dropped to near zero	Budget cap hit early, or a bid became uncon	Check budget pacing and recent bid changes
Clicks up, orders flat	Traffic quality dropped, or the listing itself changed	Check for a recent price change, stockout, or lost Buy Box
Spend way over budget	A budget increase wasn't rolled back after a	Check budget history and overspend setting
A campaign stopped delivering entirely	Out of stock, suppressed listing, or policy flag	Check listing status in Seller/Vendor Central first, not just Ads
New keywords aren't showing impressions	Bids too low for current auction competition, or	Check that keywords are bidding against the suggested range

The order to check things in

Work outside-in: listing status first (is it even buyable?), then account-level issues (budget, policy), then campaign-level (structure, bids), then keyword-level (individual terms). Most "the ads are broken" panics turn out to be a stockout or a lost Buy Box, not an ads problem at all.

When it's not an ads problem

If organic sales dropped at the same time as ad sales, or if the listing itself shows a suppression warning, a stock issue, or a price that no longer matches the Buy Box, the root cause is almost always on the catalog side — no bid or budget change in Campaign Manager will fix it. Flag it and route it to whoever owns the listing.

This is a first-pass triage guide, not an exhaustive fault tree — escalate anything that isn't resolved after these checks rather than guessing further.

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